

African American agricultural scientist and experimenter George Washington Carver helped to restore the economy in the southern US via his innovative scientific methods of soil improvement and crop cultivation. He also developed commercially viable products that could be derived from crops grown instead of cotton.

MILESTONES

FURTHER EDUCATION

Becomes first African American to enroll at Iowa State Agricultural College; gains degree in 1894.

PRODUCT RESEARCH

From 1900 to 1920, invents 287 products derived from peanuts, as well as 118 from sweet potatoes.

RECOGNITION

Speaks for peanut farmers in front of the US House of Representatives in 1921 and receives a standing ovation.

MEDALS AND HONORS

Receives multiple honors, including the Spingarn Medal in 1923, recognizing outstanding achievement.

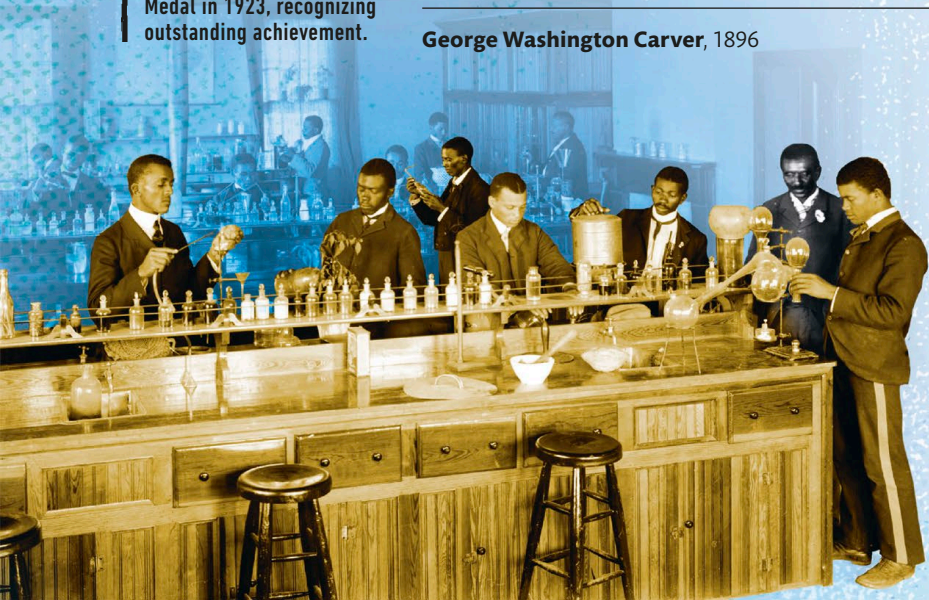
Born a slave on a Missouri plantation, Carver pursued an education following the abolition of slavery in 1865. After earning a master's degree in agriculture in 1896, he was made director of agriculture at the Tuskegee Institute, run by the renowned educator Booker T. Washington. Carver concurrently devoted himself to improving southern agriculture.

Restoring the economy

In the late 19th century, the main crop in the South was cotton, but exclusive cultivation of this crop had depleted nutrients from the soil and left yields at an all-time low. Carver encouraged farmers to grow peanuts, sweet potatoes, and soybeans instead, as these crops were nitrogen-rich and would help restore the soil. He then conducted research into derivative products that could be made from these crops, as the crops themselves were not commercially popular. Carver's work created over 400 marketable products, such as oils and dyes, which boosted financial yields and saw the South become a key contributor to the US agricultural industry.

“Education is the key to unlock the golden door of freedom.”

George Washington Carver, 1896



Carver oversaw the Agriculture Department at Tuskegee Institute, Alabama, for 47 years. In his laboratory, he taught ex-slaves sustainable farming methods and techniques to become self-sufficient.